

Consistency

One of the real conceptual breakthroughs of the Apple Desktop is that all Desktop programs behave similarly. When you see the blue desktop screen appear with the menu bar at the top, you can assume that the program does certain things in certain well-defined ways, *even if you've never used that particular program before*. For example, if you want to stop using the program, you'll always find the Quit command in the File pull-down menu. If you want to move some of your data from one part of a document to another, you first select the data you want to copy, then you use the Cut and Paste functions in the Edit menu. *Always*. Furthermore, you can safely assume that ⌘-X activates the Cut function and ⌘-V activates the Paste function.

We'll cover all of the above information in more depth later. For now, just remember that consistency is an important feature of the Apple Desktop. Individual programs may extend the desktop metaphor in ways that make sense in that program, but every true Desktop program is, to a point, similar to every other Desktop program.

Object-Action Orientation

When you're working on something in the real world, usually you first decide what you're going to work with, then you decide what you're going to do. For example, if you're proofreading your latest best-seller, you'll probably notice a misspelled word *before* you reach for your red pencil to correct it.

The Apple Desktop works the same way. In the Apple Desktop, you always select the thing you want to work on (the object) before telling the computer what to do with it (the action). For example, if you want to remove a 3.5" disk from the Finder Desktop, you'll first click on the disk, then select "Put Away" from the File menu. If you want to copy a word from a word processing document to the clipboard, you'd first select the word (by double-clicking it), then select "Copy" from the Edit pull-down menu. This object-action orientation is consistent in Desktop programs, and it's designed to make using the IIGS more like the way you really work.

Contrast this with the way programs like AppleWorks work. First you have to decide you want to delete something, then you tell it what to delete. If you change your mind about the action you want to perform, you have to cancel the operation and choose a new one. Then you have to re-select the object you want to work with—even if it's the same one as before.

In the most frequently used operations, the action and the object merge. For example, double-clicking an icon in the Finder opens it. The first click selects the object and the second click is the action, but they're so closely linked that they're one intuitive operation in the user's mind. This is the Apple Desktop at its best!